PRODUCT MANAGEMENT CASE STUDY · INDEPENDENT PORTFOLIO PROJECT

Beyond Out of Stock: Understanding Product Switching and Price Sensitivity on Blinkit

An independent product discovery and UX improvement case study.

My role: product discovery, research synthesis, prioritization, and UX concept design.
Student project, not an official Blinkit initiative.

Availability is a critical moment in quick commerce.

What Blinkit offers
• On-demand access to groceries, fresh produce, personal care, household essentials, electronics and everyday products.
• Product discovery and ordering built around convenience and rapid delivery.

Why availability matters
When a searched-for item is unavailable, users must decide whether to accept an alternative, wait or shop elsewhere.

Known: broad assortment and quick-commerce service.
Observed: out-of-stock status, Notify action and related products already exist.
Hypothesis: some users may still lack enough information to confidently choose a substitute.

Business hypothesis: clearer comparison may help users recover a purchase after an out-of-stock encounter. This is untested, not a measured business outcome.

Existing Blinkit · home

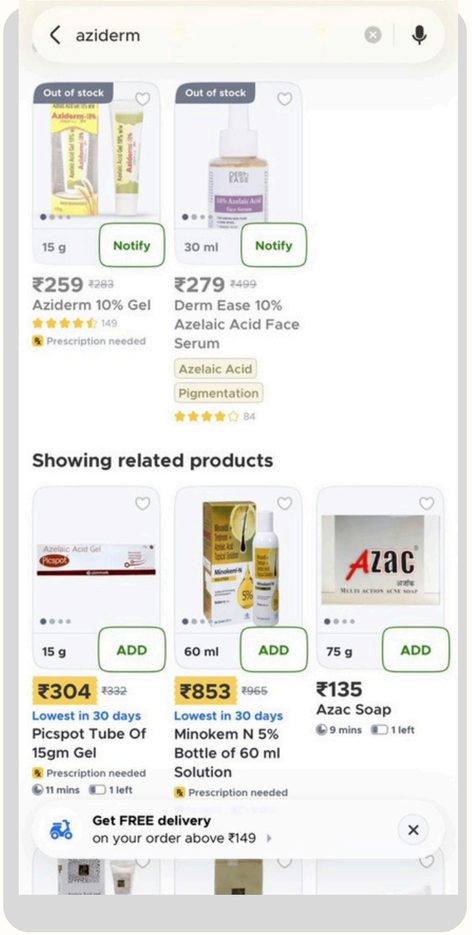


Source: Blinkit FAQ, https://blinkit.com/faq. Hypothesis informed by five exploratory interviews and the app audit.

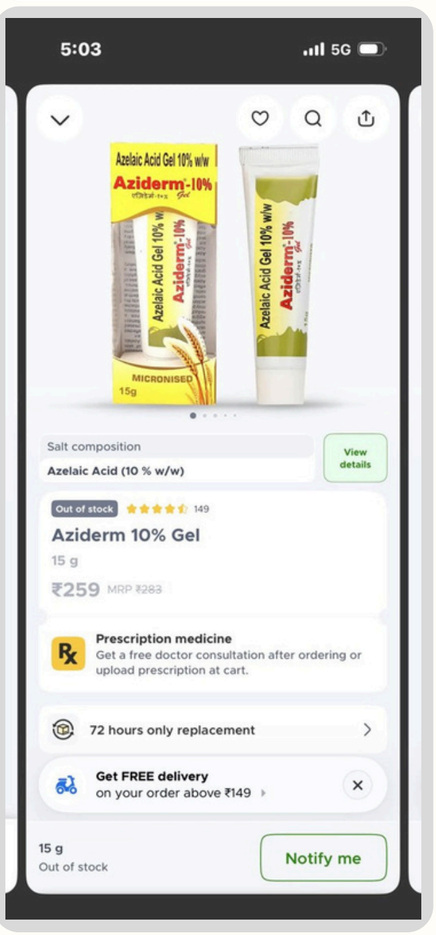
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Audit: what Blinkit already does when an item is unavailable

Search results



Product page



Observed in the audited session

- Search cards showed an out-of-stock status and “Notify”.
- Product page showed out-of-stock status, product information and “Notify me”.
- Related products appeared below, with prices, pack sizes, delivery details and ADD actions.

Potential gap

- No reason was shown for why each related item was suggested.
- No like-for-like unit-price comparison was visible in the captured screens.
- Users may need to inspect products individually to judge suitability and value.

Notify and related-product listings already exist in the observed flow. They are not new features in this proposal.

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Research methodology

1

Objective

Understand what users do when their intended product is unavailable.

2

Interview topics

Unavailable products, app switching, price sensitivity, urgency and willingness to wait.

3

Synthesis

Qualitative synthesis of recurring behaviors reported across five exploratory interviews.

4

Product audit

Own screenshots of Blinkit’s interface captured 26 Oct 2026, plus limited desk research.

Limitations

- Five interviews are not representative of all users.
- Findings do not establish how often each behavior occurs.
- Not every participant reported every behavior.
- Audit covered one account, one session and a limited set of screens.
- Competitor apps were not inspected.

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What users told us

1. Switching

Users may switch to another app when a wanted item is unavailable.
Decision: leave or stay.
Implication: the next step matters. Notify and related items already exist.
To validate: what makes a substitute acceptable?

2. Smaller price gaps

Users reported they may switch when an alternative elsewhere costs less than ₹30 the price they would have paid on Blinkit.
Decision: pay a small premium elsewhere.
Implication: a small price advantage may not retain the purchase.
To validate: test the pattern with more users.

3. Larger gaps and waiting

When the alternative elsewhere costs over ₹30 extra and the item is not urgent, users may wait for a restock.
Decision: wait or switch.
Implication: urgency and price may shape willingness to wait.
To validate: how long users actually wait.

Source: Five exploratory interviews. The ₹30 threshold is a pattern to investigate, not a universal customer rule.

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The key moment is deciding whether an alternative is a good substitute.

	Searches	Item unavailable	Compares options	Switch, substitute or wait	Buy or leave
Existing UI	Search bar, results	Out of stock tag, Notify	Related products with ADD	Notify, ADD, or leave	Not captured
Friction	None noted	No reason shown for what is related	Mixed relevance, no unit price	User must judge fit alone	Order may be lost
Opportunity	Keep flow	Explain what is closest	Compare on like terms	Decision support	Help return

Observed: out-of-stock label, Notify on card/page and related items are present. Potential friction is a hypothesis, not yet validated in usability testing.

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The opportunity is to improve decision quality, not recreate existing features.

Candidate gap	Audit observation	Verdict
Restock alert	Notify on card and page	**Exists. Rejected**
Alternatives list	"Showing related products"	**Exists. Rejected**
Relevance of alternatives	Same-ingredient gel next to a hair solution and a soap	**Supported**
Equivalence explained	Salt shown on product page only; no reason on related cards	**Supported**
Price and pack comparability	Price and pack per card; no unit price or gap vs wanted item	**Supported**
Urgency handling	Delivery time shown on cards	Unclear

Selected opportunity: test whether clearer comparison of price, quantity and relevant attributes helps users judge substitutes with less effort. One search and one category are not enough to generalize.

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Problem statement and opportunity

When a desired product is unavailable, users must decide whether to switch apps, accept an alternative or wait. Blinkit already shows related products and Notify, but the observed search did not explain why an item was related or provide a like-for-like price view.

How might we help users judge, in seconds, whether a related item is a suitable like-for-like replacement?

User need

Confidence that a swap is fair on price, size and suitability.

Business link

May reduce exits at unavailable items. Untested.

Scope

Related-products area and a compare view. No inventory change.

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Opportunity prioritization

Opportunity	Impact	Confid.	Effort	Score	Assumption behind the score
Closest-match labels + unit-price compare	4	3	2	**6.0**	Reuses existing related list and catalog attributes. Attribute quality unknown.
Smarter relevance ranking	4	2	4	**2.0**	Needs a ranking model. Mixed list suggests a gap, but one search only.
Inventory accuracy	5	2	5	**2.0**	Largest lever, but operational and unverified.
Restock alert / related list	-	-	-	**n/a**	Already exist. Not scored.

Scores are preliminary product judgments, not measurements. Comparison information is selected because it builds on existing related products and connects to interview findings about price sensitivity. Validate the problem before investing in implementation.

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Proposed solution: Closest Match

What changes

1. Rename “Showing related products” to “Closest matches” only when ranking supports that claim.
2. Add a data-supported reason chip, such as “Same product type” or “Same brand, different size”.
3. Show total price, pack size, valid unit price and price difference where meaningful.
4. Add a Compare action and keep Notify.
5. Prioritize same-type items and avoid unrelated suggestions.

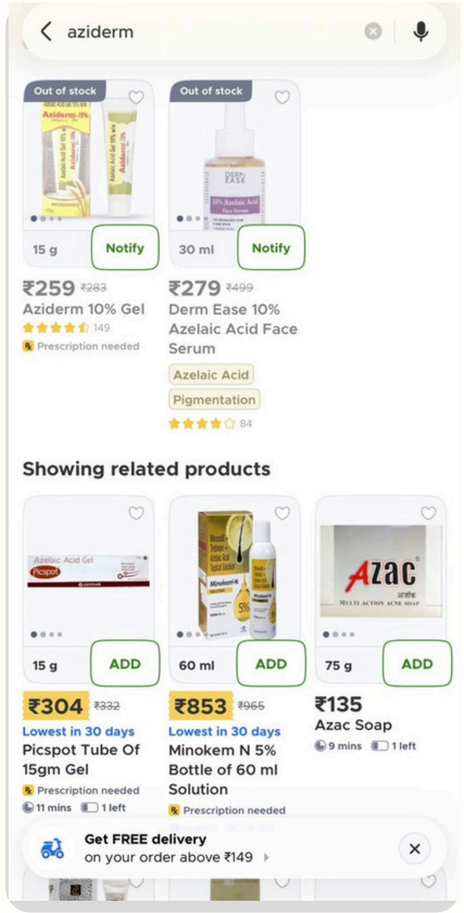
Guardrails

1. Use reliable product attributes only.
2. Test first in grocery categories.
3. Do not imply medical products are interchangeable; direct users to a doctor or pharmacist.
4. Do not promise restock timing.

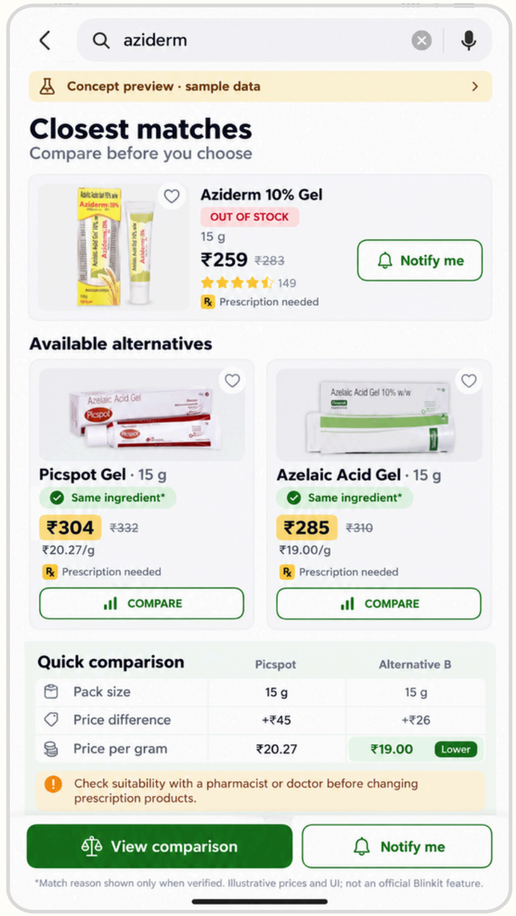
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Proposed UI 1: search results

Existing Blinkit



Proposed UI



What changed and why

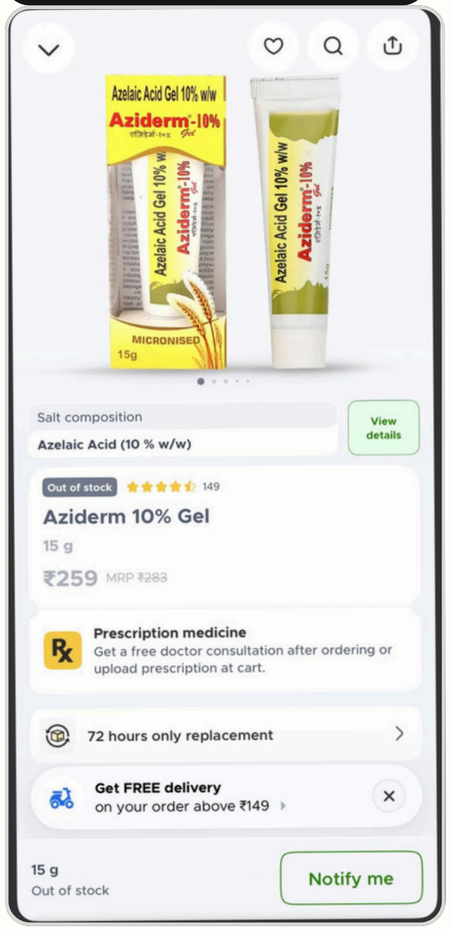
- New: reason chip, because the audit showed no stated reason for related items.
- New: unit price and price gap, to make like-for-like comparison easier.
- Kept: product images, Notify, ADD and existing layout patterns.
- Alt B and its prices are illustrative; Picspot values reflect the captured screen.

Source: Own captures of the Blinkit app, 26 Oct 2026, about 5:03 PM IST (device status bar). Direct observation, one account, one session. Proposed screen is a concept, not a Blinkit feature.

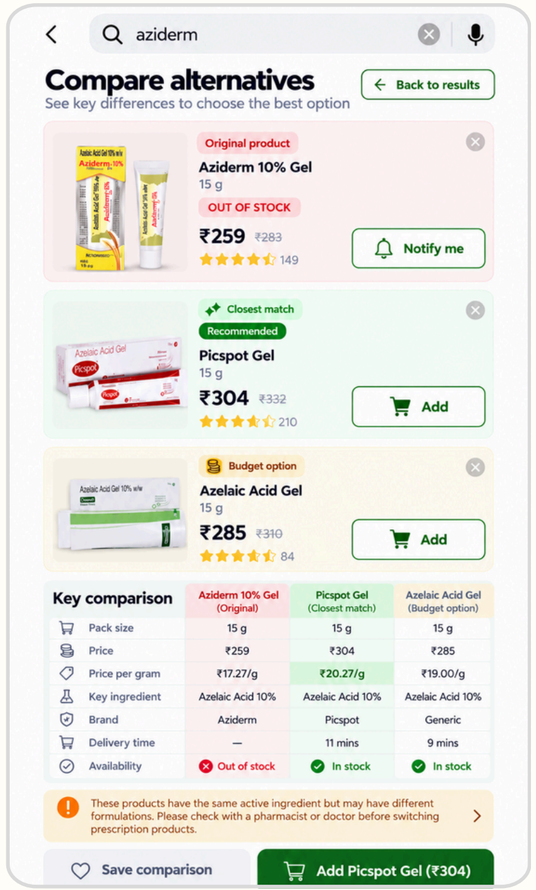
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Proposed UI 2: product page and compare view

Existing Blinkit



Proposed UI



Why this may help

- Today: users may need to open pages and calculate unit prices themselves.
- Proposed: total price and unit price appear side by side.
- Notify remains available, so waiting is still an option.
- Concept only; values are illustrative and this is not advice to substitute medicines.

Source: Own captures of the Blinkit app, 26 Oct 2026, about 5:03 PM IST (device status bar). Direct observation, one account, one session. Not a recommendation to substitute medicines.

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Test whether comparison helps users choose with less effort.

Out-of-stock search › **Closest matches** › **Compare view** › **Add, notify or leave**

Task 1

Find a suitable replacement for an unavailable item.

Task 2

Compare two alternatives and say which is better value for your need.

Task 3

Add, notify or abandon, and explain why.

Measure task completion, comparison errors, time to decision and self-reported confidence. Test the current and proposed experience with comparable tasks and identical product information. Start with grocery categories. Concept only; no results are claimed.

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Success metrics and experiment plan

Primary: immediate out-of-stock recovery rate. Numerator: eligible out-of-stock encounters that result in a completed purchase through the alternative-selection journey. Denominator: all eligible out-of-stock encounters assigned to that experience.

Supporting

- Compare open rate
- Add rate from Closest Matches
- Conversion after an unavailable encounter
- Notify opt-in rate
- Exit rate after an unavailable encounter

Guardrails

- Returns and cancellations on substitutes
- Customer satisfaction
- Unsuitable substitution reports
- Extra friction or slower decisions

Controlled test (to define first)

- Compare current related products with Closest Match for eligible products with reliable attributes.
- Define baseline, eligibility, measurement window, sample size and success threshold before launch.
- Measure purchases after restock notifications separately.
- No outcomes or uplift are claimed.

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Risks, trade-offs and next steps

Value to users

Users may not value comparison enough to change behavior.

Data quality

Pack sizes, strengths and ingredients must be accurate and complete.

False equivalence

Look-alike products may not be suitable swaps, especially medicines.

Ranking influence

Whether related items are affected by ads or promotions: not verified.

Evidence limits

Five interviews and one captured search.

Next step

Repeat the audit across 3–5 grocery products. Check existing price/quantity information, then test the current and proposed screens with users. Refine or reject the concept based on evidence.

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Conclusion and references

Conclusion

- Insight: small price gaps may encourage switching; larger gaps may encourage waiting.
- Verified: Blinkit already offers Notify and related products.
- Gap: no stated match reason or like-for-like price view in one observed search.
- Proposal: Closest Match is a hypothesis, not a validated feature.
- Next: replicate the audit and run usability tests.

Screenshots: own captures of the Blinkit app, 26 Oct 2026, about 5:03 PM IST. Home-screen address line was masked.

References

- Blinkit FAQ: https://blinkit.com/faq
- Eternal Limited, Q2 FY27 shareholder letter and results, 21 Oct 2026.
- Own Blinkit app screenshots captured 26 Oct 2026.
- Five exploratory user interviews for this independent case study.
- Competitor apps were not inspected; competitor claims are not used as verified evidence.

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